Acknowledging that diplomacy is the weakest indicator and has the potential to be labelled “empty talk,” Koga argues that the diplomatic factor becomes particularly important when either the military or economic factor in a state’s behaviour signals a clear move towards more confrontation or more cooperation.[59] Hence, if the alignment and military indicators do not give a clear signal of State A’s policy behaviour, we need to include policies along the economic and diplomatic indicators to understand the policy stance of State A vis-à-vis States B and C. The economic and diplomatic variables are nevertheless valuable for understanding nuanced hedging behaviour and changes of policy in one specific direction.

The next challenge in our study is how to measure balancing, conflictive hedging, extensive hedging, cooperative hedging, and bandwagoning behaviour within each of the four indicators – alignment, military and defence policies, economic policies, and diplomacy. Paul argues that, although traditional balancing through alliance formation and military build-ups are the most significant forms of balance-of-power behaviour, there is a need to broaden the concept of power behaviour.[60] One strand of this debate is about improving the metrics for identifying the traditional internal and external balancing strategies.[61] In the following, we outline the broad definitions of state behaviour on each of the four indicators (see also Figure 1.3).

Alignment Policies: Alignment policies can be divided into strong, moderate, and weak alignment.[62] Strong alignment corresponds with traditional hard external balancing and in our case would include entering into a formal military alliance with the United States and being open for US or other allied troops based in India on a permanent or semi-permanent basis. Moderate alignment signals, which correspond with signals of conflictive hedging, are rotational allied troop deployments or limited access agreements; participation in US-led operations; and joint training,